



Mindfulness on the Mats™

Instructor Onboarding Guide

Your Foundation Before Month 1

Read before introducing Mindfulness on the Mats™ to your students.

MOTM SUBSCRIPTION — ONBOARDING DOCUMENT

What You Are Holding

Welcome to Mindfulness on the Mats™. This document is your foundation. Before you introduce a single script to your students, read this guide in full. It contains everything you need to understand what this curriculum is, why it works, and exactly how to deliver it in your school.

Starting next month, you will receive one new Module PDF each month — Breath, Body, Mind, and then Spirit — each containing five scripts, one for each week of class. Today's document gives you the theory, the framework, and the opening "Mat Chat" that launches the whole program.

Your Monthly Drip Schedule

Document	When You Receive It	What It Contains
Onboarding Guide (This Doc)	Before Month 1	Theory, science, framework, Mat Chat
Module 1: BREATH	Month 1	5 scripts + Young Warriors + Challenges
Module 2: BODY	Month 2	5 scripts + Young Warriors + Challenges
Module 3: MIND	Month 3	5 scripts + Young Warriors + Challenges

Module 4: SPIRIT	Month 4	5 scripts + Young Warriors + Challenges
Instructor Resource Pack	Month 1 (companion)	Quick Ref, Parent Handout, Certs, Glossary

How to use each Module: Each module contains five scripts — one per week. Run the script at the opening or close of class (3–5 minutes). The module then rotates: Month 1 is Breath, Month 2 is Body, Month 3 is Mind, Month 4 is Spirit. At Month 5, you return to Breath — but your students will go deeper because they've been through the cycle. New students can join at any point and still get the full value of whichever module is current.



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About the Author

Mindfulness on the Mats™ was founded by **Dr. Joseph Assouline, PsyD**, a clinical psychologist with over twenty years of experience practicing and teaching the martial arts. Dr. Assouline has served as both program director and manager for two martial arts studios. He combines his two passions — mindfulness meditation and the martial arts — to bring evidence-based mental training directly to the dojo.

He provides workshops and private consultation for individuals (children and adults) who wish to incorporate mindfulness meditation in their martial arts studios, their personal practice, and in their lives.

Disclaimer

The Mindfulness on the Mats™ (MOTM) curriculum is educational in nature ONLY. Although mindfulness meditation has been shown to have therapeutic effects, by using this curriculum you are not providing therapy or creating a psychotherapeutic relationship with your students. Nor is Mindfulness on the Mats™ creating a therapy relationship with its consumers. If expert assistance or counseling is needed, the services of a competent professional should be sought.

What is Mindfulness?

Mindfulness is not new to the martial arts. It is not something that only belongs in yoga studios or therapy sessions. As martial artists and athletes, we train both our body and mind to be aware of what is going on inside and outside of us. When training katas and techniques, we pay attention to where each part of the body is at any given moment. We notice our opponent's body language to predict their next move. In a sense, we are already training mindfully.

Mindfulness meditation is a state of mind and vantage point from which to observe one's experience and environment. It is a way to bring oneself back to the present moment, non-judgmentally. It is noticing what is, in the here and now — without getting caught up in thoughts, feelings, or body sensations.

You may have experienced this when grappling, sparring, competing, or performing a kata, when you're in a state of flow and everything around you disappears. All that matters is the here and now and your current goal. This is called **mindful awareness**.

History: From Ancient Roots to Modern Practice

Aspects of mindfulness meditation originate from 2,500-year-old Buddhist practices and traditions. In the martial arts, mindfulness can be found in the Daoist concepts of **Zanshin** and **Mushin**.

Zanshin is a spiritual, physical, and mental awareness of yourself within your surroundings so that you can react effectively to attackers.

Mushin (Japanese) or **Wuxin** (Chinese) means "no mind" or "without mind" — a state where the mind is not preoccupied or fixated on one thought or emotion, leaving it more flexible and open. This allows the individual to move freely based on intuition, beyond the obstacles of hesitation or self-judgment. This mental

state is also described as a state of "flow."

Modern pioneers including Jon Kabat-Zinn, Herbert Benson, Richard J. Davidson, Sharon Salzberg, and Jack Kornfield have brought mindfulness into contemporary secular settings: schools, the military, boardrooms, and now — the dojo.



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The Science of the Mindful Warrior

Research on mindfulness has made leaps and bounds in the past 30 years. The science confirms what masters have known for centuries: training the mind is just as measurable and impactful as training the body.

The Neurobiology of the Fighter

Mindfulness does not just change how we feel — it changes the physical structure of the brain, a concept known as **neuroplasticity**. Three brain changes are particularly relevant to the martial artist:

Brain Region	Role	Effect of Mindfulness
Amygdala (The Alarm Bell)	Triggers "fight, flight, or freeze" response	Mindfulness decreases density and reactivity. You are less likely to panic — more likely to stay calm and tactical.
Prefrontal Cortex (The Commander)	Decision-making, focus, impulse control	Mindfulness is linked to cortical thickening. A stronger commander helps you stick to strategy rather than brawling emotionally.
Hippocampus (The Librarian)	Learning, memory, and stress regulation	Mindfulness increases gray matter density. This aids retention of complex techniques and helps regulate the stress response.

Performance: Getting the Edge

Improved Reaction Time & Attention: Research on military cohorts shows mindfulness training improves working memory and sustains attention in high-stress environments, allowing faster processing of visual stimuli such as an opponent's jab or kick.

Flow State Accessibility: Mindfulness facilitates the "flow" state (Mushin) by helping athletes let go of distraction and self-judgment — the two biggest barriers to high performance.

Pain Management & Recovery: Mindfulness alters the subjective experience of pain and lowers cortisol levels, which can speed up physical recovery time between training sessions.

The Curriculum Framework

The MOTM curriculum is a holistic approach to mindfulness for martial artists and athletes. Lessons are split into four modules that build awareness from the ground up:

Module	Theme	Core Focus
I — BREATH	Month 1	Harnessing energy, grounding, emotional regulation through breath
II — BODY	Month 2	Proprioception, tension release, physical alignment and grounding
III — MIND	Month 3	Zanshin (awareness), Mushin (no mind), mental flexibility
IV — SPIRIT	Month 4	Flow state, purpose, equanimity, self-compassion

Scripts vs. Challenges

Scripts are guided exercises read to students while they are in a meditative stance (on their knees, in a horse stance, or in a comfortable stable position). Run one script per class session, at the opening or close of class (3–5 minutes).

Challenges are integration activities meant to be woven into the martial arts lesson itself — during forms, sparring, or drills. They make the script functional by asking students to apply the concept while training.

Being Trauma-Informed

Every student has their own past experiences, culture, and background. Sometimes students have experienced emotional or physical trauma that can make looking inward uncomfortable or even feel dangerous. Always give students an "out" before every exercise:

"If at any point this exercise becomes too uncomfortable and you need to stop or take a break, please do so."

It is important for students to build tolerance to their experience, but it is equally important that no student is re-traumatized and that everyone feels safe on the mats.

Inviting the Sidelines

Do not hesitate to invite parents and guardians observing the class to participate from their seats. When parents engage alongside their children, they powerfully model self-regulation. This shared experience brings the calm of the dojo into the home and creates a common language for handling stress.

Age Group Guidance

Age Group	Which Scripts to Use	Instructor Notes
Ages 3–6 (Young Warriors)	Young Warriors scripts included at the end of each Module PDF	Use playful, game-based language. Movement is encouraged.
Ages 7–11 (Twens)	Young Warriors scripts with more mature naming (e.g., "Vibration Breath" instead of "Bumblebee Breath")	Rename exercises to sound less childish. Bridge to adult concepts.
Ages 12+ (Teens & Adults)	Standard adult scripts in each Module PDF	Focus heavily on performance benefits: reaction time, power, mental edge. Avoid emotional framing.

Teaching Teens: The Performance Pivot

Teenagers are often self-conscious. When teaching them, focus heavily on the **performance benefits** — reaction time, power, speed, mental edge — rather than the emotional benefits. If they believe it will make them a better fighter, they will buy in. Use language from the Troubleshooting Guide (included in your Resource Pack): "We are thickening the prefrontal cortex so you don't freeze in a real fight. This is brain conditioning."

Mat Chat: Introducing the Mindful Warrior

Time: Approx. 3–5 Minutes · Deliver this ONCE before your first script in Month 1.

Goal: Define mindfulness, explain the purpose of the program, and set safety expectations.

(Instructor calls the class to a comfortable seated position — knees or cross-legged.)

*"We spend hours every week training our bodies. We train our muscles to be strong, our cardio to be strong, and our technique to be sharp and fast. But there is one muscle we often forget to train, and it's the most important one for a martial artist: **The Mind**.*

*Starting today, we are introducing a new training tool called **Mindfulness on the Mats™**. Mindfulness isn't new to the martial arts. In fact, the ancient masters called it Zanshin — total awareness of yourself and your surroundings.*

Think about it like this: When you throw a punch, if you overextend your arm, you lose your balance and leave yourself open to a counterattack. Our minds do the same thing. When we get angry, frustrated, or distracted, our minds overextend. We lose our 'mental center.' We stop paying attention to what is happening right here, right now. And in a fight, or in life, that's when we get hit, hurt, or worse.

*Over the next few months, we are going to move through four modules: **Breath, Body, Mind, and Spirit**. We are going to learn how to:*

*Use our **Breath** to generate power and calm us down.*

*Scan our **Body** to find tension that slows us down and to use our bodies more effectively.*

*Train our **Mind** to let go of distractions — what we call Mushin, or 'No Mind.'*

*Find our **Spirit**, or 'flow state' — where you move without hesitation and everything comes together.*

Two important rules before we start:

First: *This is training, just like push-ups. It might feel weird or difficult at first. That's okay. Just try your best.*

Second: *Everyone is different. Sometimes, closing your eyes or looking inside can feel uncomfortable. If we are doing a breathing exercise and you feel unsafe or uncomfortable, you have an 'out'. You can open your eyes, take a break, or just sit quietly. You are in control.*

We are doing this to make you better martial artists and stronger people. Let's get started with our first drill.

Parents, *feel free to join in — mindfulness is a tool that strengthens the whole family, not just the student."*